

Rough



Common opal | The majority of opal is “common” opal – material that has neither transparency or fire. Here, pink common opal is in a rock groundmass.

Opal material



Opal nodule | Much Australian precious opal is found in nodules, occasionally replacing fossils. This white-base nodule is from Coober Pede, Australia.



Opal in ironstone | Some Australian precious opal has formed simultaneously with ironstone and is interlayered with it, as in this specimen.

Cut



Boulder opal | This cabochon has been cut from small layers of opal intermixed with ironstone matrix. This mixture is known as “boulder” opal.



Conchoidal fracture

Fire opal | Opal that is transparent or translucent red or orange is called “fire” opal. This rough specimen has a fine deep colouring.



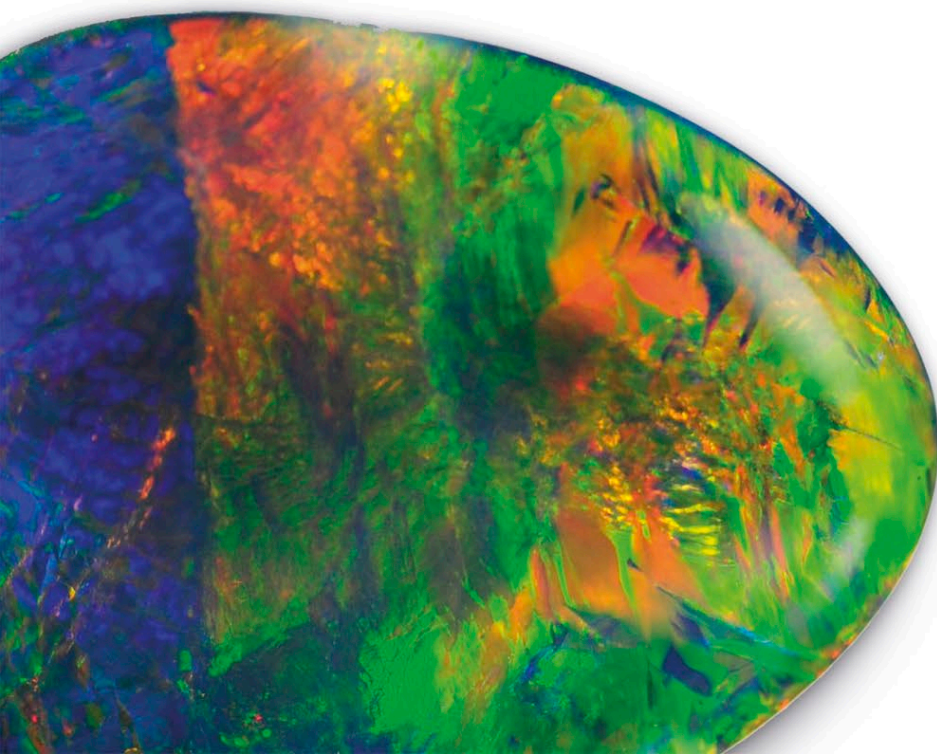
Yellow common opal

Precious opal

Ironstone matrix | This specimen represents a colourful example of Australian opal. It has developed in an ironstone matrix and consists of a mixture of precious opal and yellow common opal, or “potch” opal.



Faceted opal | Some fire opal (sometimes called “jelly” opal) is transparent enough to facet. This orange brilliant cushion is cut from Mexican fire opal.



“Island Sunset” opal | This stunning black opal weighs 28.10 carats and was found at Lightning Ridge, Australia (see pp.162–63). It has been cut into a wide drop shape.

Faint patterning



Ethiopian opal | In recent years, a new discovery in Ethiopia has produced notable amounts of precious opal, as seen in this freeform cabochon.